React + Next.js + Node.js — Developer Resources

> Every resource a pro reaches for. Bookmark this. You'll rotate through these on every project.

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Templates & Starters

Resource	What you get	URL
Vercel Templates	Production-ready Next.js starters, many with auth + DB already wired	vercel.com/templates
create-t3-app	The most popular opinionated Next.js starter — Next + tRPC + Prisma + Auth + Tailwind	create.t3.gg

Resource	What you get	URL
Shadcn Taxonomy	Open source app built with everything in your stack — study the code	github.com/shadcn-ui/taxonomy
Shadcn Examples	Official examples — dashboard, music app, mail app	ui.shadcn.com/examples

> **When to use:** Start every new project here. Don't build your 5th boilerplate from scratch.

UI Blocks & Components

Resource	What you get	URL
shadcn/ui Blocks	Full page sections — hero, pricing, dashboard — copy paste ready	ui.shadcn.com/blocks
MagicUI	Animated components built on top of shadcn + Framer Motion	magicui.design
Aceternity UI	Stunning effects — 3D cards, spotlight, beam, moving borders	ui.aceternity.com
AnimataUI	Animated components, free	animata.design
Origin UI	Large collection of shadcn component variants	originui.com
Shadcn UI Expansions	Extra components not in core shadcn	shadcnui-expansions.typeart.cc
Tailwind UI	Paid — but the gold standard of Tailwind components	tailwindui.com

> **When to use:** shadcn Blocks first for layouts. MagicUI and Aceternity for wow moments. Origin UI when you need a shadcn component variant you can't find in the docs.

Icons & Illustrations

Icons

Resource	What you get	URL
Lucide	Your primary icon set — browse all icons	lucide.dev

Resource	What you get	URL
Heroicons	Tailwind's official icons	heroicons.com
Phosphor Icons	More expressive, multiple weights	phosphoricons.com
Radix Icons	Minimal icons, pairs well with shadcn	radix-ui.com/icons
Tabler Icons	4000+ free icons	tabler.io/icons

Illustrations

Resource	What you get	URL
unDraw	Free illustrations, brand colour adjustable	undraw.co
Storyset	Free customisable illustrated scenes	storyset.com
Humaaans	Mix-and-match people illustrations	humaaans.com
Blush	Customisable illustration collections	blush.design

Animations

Resource	What you get	URL
LottieFiles	Free Lottie animations — loading screens, empty states, success	lottiefiles.com
UseAnimations	Animated icons (free tier available)	useanimations.com

> **When to use:** unDraw and Storyset for empty states and onboarding. LottieFiles for loading screens and success states. They make your app feel finished.

Fonts

Resource	What you get	URL
Google Fonts	Free fonts, works directly with `next/font`	fonts.google.com
Fontshare	High quality free fonts from Indian Type Foundry	fontshare.com
Font Pair	Curated heading + body combinations	fontpair.co
Typescale	Preview your type scale visually before coding it	typescale.com

Resource	What you get	URL
Fonts In Use	See what fonts real companies use	fontsinuse.com
Variable Fonts	Browse fonts that support variable weight/width	v-fonts.com

Recommended Free Fonts

Font	Vibe	Get it from
Inter	Clean SaaS, neutral	Google Fonts
Geist	Modern developer tool	Google Fonts
Plus Jakarta Sans	Friendly dashboard	Google Fonts
DM Sans	Minimal, modern	Google Fonts
Cabinet Grotesk	Bold, editorial	Fontshare
Satoshi	Geometric, premium feel	Fontshare
General Sans	Versatile, professional	Fontshare
Clash Display	Strong display headings	Fontshare

> **Rule:** Pick one from Google Fonts or Fontshare. Don't mix more than two fonts in a project.

Colours & Gradients

Resource	What you get	URL
shadcn Themes	Drop-in CSS variable palettes for your stack	ui.shadcn.com/themes
Realtime Colors	Preview your palette on a real UI as you build	realtimecolors.com
Coolors	Palette generator and explorer	coolors.co
UIColors	Tailwind-compatible colour shade generator	uicolors.app
Hypercolor	Tailwind gradient combinations ready to copy	hypercolor.dev
Gradienta	Mesh gradients, free CSS to copy	gradienta.io
CSS Gradient	Visual gradient builder	cssgradient.io
Color Hunt	Curated colour palettes	colorhunt.co

Resource	What you get	URL
Reasonable Colors	Accessible, WCAG-safe Tailwind colour pairings	reasonable.work/colors

> **Workflow:** Pick a palette in Realtime Colors → copy the CSS variables → paste into `globals.css`. Done in 2 minutes.

Backgrounds & Textures

Resource	What you get	URL
SVG Backgrounds	Customisable SVG patterns and textures	svgbackgrounds.com
Hero Patterns	Repeating SVG patterns for backgrounds	heropatterns.com
Haikei	Generate blob, wave, and layered SVG shapes	haikei.app
Shapedivider	Custom section dividers between page sections	shapedivider.app
Noise & Texture	CSS noise texture generator	noiseandtexture.com
Mesh Gradient	Beautiful mesh gradient generator	meshgradient.in
CSS Pattern	Pure CSS background patterns	css-pattern.com

> **Most used:** Haikei for hero blobs. Shapedivider between landing page sections. Mesh Gradient for hero backgrounds.

Images & Media

Resource	What you get	URL
Unsplash	Free high quality photos	unsplash.com
Pexels	Free photos and videos	pexels.com
Pixabay	Free photos, illustrations, videos	pixabay.com
Squoosh	Compress and convert images before adding to your project	squoosh.app
Mockuphone	Device mockups for your app screenshots	mockuphone.com
Screely	Beautiful browser mockup for screenshots	screely.com

Resource	What you get	URL
RealFaviconGenerator	Generate all PWA icon sizes from one image	realfavicongenerator.net
Blurred	Generate blurDataURL for Next.js image placeholders	blurred.dev
Remove.bg	Remove image background in one click	remove.bg
Tinypng	Compress PNG and JPG	tinypng.com

> **Always run Squoosh or Tinypng on every image before adding it to your project.** Large images are the most common cause of slow pages.

Code & Inspiration

Design Inspiration

Resource	What you get	URL
Dribbble	Design inspiration — search for what you're building	dribbble.com
Awwwards	The best websites on the internet, curated	awwwards.com
Godly	Curated stunning websites	godly.website
Lands.xyz	Landing page inspiration	lands.xyz
Lapa Ninja	Landing page design inspiration	lapa.ninja
SaaS Landing Page	SaaS-specific landing page examples	saaslandingpage.com
Mobbin	Mobile app UI patterns and flows	mobbin.com
Pageflows	User flow recordings of real apps	pageflows.com

Code References

Resource	What you get	URL
Shadcn Taxonomy	Full open source Next.js app to read and learn from	github.com/shadcn-ui/taxonomy
Vercel Examples	Official Next.js example apps	github.com/vercel/next.js/tree/canary/examples

Resource	What you get	URL
JavaScript Algorithms	Algorithms and data structures in JS	github.com/trekhleb/javascript-algorithms
Shadcn UI	Read the source code of components you use	github.com/shadcn-ui/ui

> **Tip:** When you see a website you like, open DevTools and inspect it. More educational than any tutorial.

Learning

Official Docs (bookmark these, not random blog posts)

Resource	URL
Next.js Docs	nextjs.org/docs
React Docs	react.dev
Tailwind Docs	tailwindcss.com/docs
shadcn/ui Docs	ui.shadcn.com
Framer Motion Docs	framer.com/motion
Lucide Docs	lucide.dev
Prisma Docs	prisma.io/docs
Vercel Docs	vercel.com/docs
Node.js Docs	nodejs.org/docs
Express Docs	expressjs.com
Hono Docs	hono.dev

YouTube Channels

Channel	Best for
Fireship	Fast overviews of new tools and concepts
Theo (t3.gg)	Opinionated takes on the modern JS stack

Channel	Best for
Josh tried coding	Next.js + shadcn project tutorials
Jack Herrington	Deep dives into React and Next.js internals
Kevin Powell	CSS mastery — the best CSS teacher on YouTube
Traversy Media	Beginner-friendly project tutorials including Node
Dave Gray	Node.js and Express from scratch, very clear
Codevolution	Node + Express + REST API tutorials

Blogs & Newsletters

Resource	Best for	URL
Josh Comeau's Blog	Deep, visual CSS and React explanations	joshwcomeau.com
Lee Robinson's Blog	Next.js best practices from Vercel's VP	leerob.io
Bytes Newsletter	Fun weekly JS newsletter	bytes.dev
CSS Tricks	CSS patterns and techniques	css-tricks.com
Node Weekly	Weekly Node.js news and articles	nodeweekly.com

Node.js Resources

> These are specific to Node.js as a standalone backend — separate from what Next.js already gives you.

Backend Frameworks

Framework	Best for	URL
Express ✅ learn first	The classic — most tutorials, most Stack Overflow answers, most jobs	expressjs.com
Fastify	Faster Express, better TypeScript, schema validation built in	fastify.dev
Hono	Lightweight, runs on Node + edge runtimes (Vercel, Cloudflare)	hono.dev
Elysia	Modern, fast, great DX — built for Bun runtime	elysiajs.com

Framework	Best for	URL
NestJS	Opinionated, Angular-like structure — popular in enterprise	nestjs.com

> **Rule: Learn Express first — the concepts transfer to everything else. Move to Hono or Fastify once you understand middleware, routing, and REST.**

Essential Node.js Packages

Core

Package	What it does	Install
express	Web framework	`npm i express`
dotenv	Load `.env` files	`npm i dotenv`
cors	Enable CORS for frontend requests	`npm i cors`
helmet	Security headers in one line	`npm i helmet`
morgan	HTTP request logger	`npm i morgan`
compression	Gzip responses	`npm i compression`

Validation

Package	What it does	Install
zod	Schema validation — same as your frontend	`npm i zod`
express-validator	Request validation middleware for Express	`npm i express-validator`

Database

Package	What it does	Install
prisma	ORM — works with Postgres, MySQL, SQLite	`npm i prisma`
@supabase/supabase-js	Supabase client	`npm i @supabase/supabase-js`
mongoose	MongoDB ODM	`npm i mongoose`
ioredis	Redis client	`npm i ioredis`

Auth

Package	What it does	Install
jsonwebtoken	Create and verify JWTs	`npm i jsonwebtoken`
bcryptjs	Hash passwords	`npm i bcryptjs`
passport	Auth middleware — many strategies	`npm i passport`

File handling

Package	What it does	Install
multer	Handle file uploads in Express	`npm i multer`
sharp	Image processing (resize, convert, compress)	`npm i sharp`

Utilities

Package	What it does	Install
axios	HTTP client for calling external APIs	`npm i axios`
node-cron	Schedule jobs with cron syntax	`npm i node-cron`
uuid	Generate unique IDs	`npm i uuid`
lodash	Utility functions	`npm i lodash`
dayjs	Date manipulation (lighter than moment.js)	`npm i dayjs`
socket.io	WebSockets — real-time bidirectional events	`npm i socket.io`

Dev tools

Package	What it does	Install
nodemon	Auto-restart server on file changes	`npm i -D nodemon`
tsx	Run TypeScript directly without compiling	`npm i -D tsx`
@types/node	TypeScript types for Node.js	`npm i -D @types/node`
@types/express	TypeScript types for Express	`npm i -D @types/express`

Node.js Project Structure

```
my-api/
├── src/
|   ├── index.js              ← entry point, starts the server
|   ├── app.js                ← express app setup, middleware
|   ├── routes/
|   |   ├── users.js          ← /api/users
|   |   ├── posts.js          ← /api/posts
|   |   └── auth.js           ← /api/auth
|   ├── controllers/
|   |   ├── users.controller.js   ← handler functions
|   |   └── posts.controller.js
|   ├── middleware/
|   |   ├── auth.middleware.js     ← protect routes
|   |   └── error.middleware.js    ← global error handler
|   ├── lib/
|   |   ├── prisma.js             ← prisma client instance
|   |   └── redis.js              ← redis client instance
|   └── utils/
|       └── response.js           ← consistent API response helpers
├── prisma/
|   └── schema.prisma
├── .env
├── .env.example
└── package.json
```

The Express Boilerplate Pattern

```js
// src/app.js
import express from 'express';
import cors from 'cors';
import helmet from 'helmet';
import morgan from 'morgan';
import { userRoutes } from './routes/users.js';
import { errorMiddleware } from './middleware/error.middleware.js';

const app = express();

// Middleware
app.use(helmet());
app.use(cors({ origin: process.env.CLIENT_URL }));
app.use(morgan('dev'));
app.use(express.json());

// Routes
app.use('/api/users', userRoutes);

// 404
app.use((req, res) => {
  res.status(404).json({ error: 'Route not found' });
});

// Global error handler — always last
app.use(errorMiddleware);

export default app;
```

```js
// src/index.js
import app from './app.js';

const PORT = process.env.PORT || 3001;

app.listen(PORT, () => {
  console.log(`Server running on port ${PORT}`);
});
```

```js
```

```
// src/middleware/error.middleware.js
export function errorMiddleware(err, req, res, next) {
  const status = err.status ?? 500;
  const message = err.message ?? 'Internal server error';
  console.error(err);
  res.status(status).json({ error: message });
}
```

```js
// src/utils/response.js — consistent API responses
export const sendSuccess = (res, data, status = 200) =>
  res.status(status).json({ success: true, data });

export const sendError = (res, message, status = 400) =>
  res.status(status).json({ success: false, error: message });
```

When to Use Next.js API Routes vs Node.js

Situation	Use
Simple CRUD tied to your Next.js app	Next.js API routes
The same API serves a mobile app too	Node.js separate backend
You need WebSockets	Node.js + Socket.io
Long-running processes (video processing etc.)	Node.js
Multiple frontend apps share one backend	Node.js
Quick prototype, solo project	Next.js API routes
Team where backend and frontend are separate	Node.js

Node.js Learning Path

```
Step 1 — Fundamentals
  Node.js Docs → nodejs.org/docs
  What is Node, event loop, modules, fs, path, http

Step 2 — Express basics
```

```
  expressjs.com/en/starter/basic-routing.html
  Routing, middleware, request/response, error handling

Step 3 — REST API
  Build a full CRUD API with Express + Prisma + Postgres
  GET /posts, POST /posts, PUT /posts/:id, DELETE /posts/:id

Step 4 — Auth
  JWT pattern — register, login, protected routes
  bcryptjs for passwords, jsonwebtoken for tokens

Step 5 — Real project
  Build a Node backend your Next.js frontend calls
  Deploy it on Railway
```

> **YouTube:** Dave Gray's Node.js + Express series is the clearest free resource for learning this in order.

Developer Tools

VS Code Extensions

Extension	What it does
ES7+ React Snippets	Type `rafce` and get a full component
Tailwind CSS IntelliSense	Autocomplete for Tailwind classes
Prettier	Auto-formats your code on save
ESLint	Catches errors before they happen
Auto Rename Tag	Renames closing tag when you rename opening
GitLens	See who wrote every line and when
Error Lens	Shows errors inline, not just in the problems panel
Import Cost	Shows the bundle size of every import

Browser Extensions

Extension	What it does
React DevTools	Inspect component tree and state

Extension	What it does
Tailwind DevTools	Inspect Tailwind classes in the browser
ColorZilla	Pick any colour from any website
WhatFont	Click any text to see its font
Lighthouse	Built into Chrome DevTools — audit performance

Online Tools

Tool	What it does	URL
Ray.so	Beautiful code screenshots to share	ray.so
Transform	Convert JSON to TypeScript types instantly	transform.tools
Regex101	Build and test regex with explanations	regex101.com
JSON Formatter	Format and validate JSON	jsonformatter.curiousconcept.com
Bundle Phobia	Check npm package size before installing	bundlephobia.com
Can I Use	Check browser support for CSS/JS features	caniuse.com
Excalidraw	Whiteboard for planning UI and architecture	excalidraw.com

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The Honest Shortcut Order

How to use these resources when starting a new project:

```
Day 1 — Foundation
  1. Pick a starter      → Vercel Templates or create-t3-app
  2. Pick a font         → Fontshare (Satoshi or Cabinet Grotesk) or Google Fonts
(Inter)
  3. Pick a palette      → Realtime Colors → paste into globals.css
  4. Generate icons      → RealFaviconGenerator for PWA icons

Week 1 — Building
  5. Grab layouts        → shadcn Blocks for hero, pricing, dashboard sections
  6. Grab illustrations  → unDraw or Storyset for empty states and onboarding
  7. Grab animations     → MagicUI or Aceternity for wow moments
  8. Compress images     → Squoosh before every image you add

When stuck on design
  9. Get inspired        → Godly or Awwwards
  10. Check mobile flows → Mobbin for native app patterns

When stuck on code
  11. Read the docs      → nextjs.org/docs first, always
  12. Study real code    → Shadcn Taxonomy source code
  13. Watch Theo or Josh → for your specific stack

Before shipping
  14. Run Lighthouse     → Chrome DevTools → Lighthouse tab
  15. Check BundlePhobia → for any large packages you added
  16. Run Squoosh        → on every image one more time
```

Don't try to use everything at once. The best resource is always the official docs for whatever you're currently building.

Platforms — Where to Go for What

> Every category has 3-5 options. This cuts through the noise and tells you which one to pick and when.

Hosting & Deployment

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Vercel ✅ first choice	Next.js apps — built by the same team, zero config	Yes	vercel.com

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Netlify	Static sites, simple full-stack apps	Yes	netlify.com
Railway	Full-stack apps that need a persistent server, background jobs	Yes (limited)	railway.app
Render	Full-stack + databases, good Heroku alternative	Yes (sleeps)	render.com
Fly.io	Docker containers, global edge deployment	Yes	fly.io
AWS / GCP / Azure	Enterprise scale — don't touch until you need it	No	—

Rule: Start on Vercel. Move to Railway or Render when you need a persistent server or background jobs. Ignore AWS until you have real scale problems.

Database

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Supabase ✅ first choice	Postgres + auth + storage + realtime in one — open source	Yes	supabase.com
PlanetScale	MySQL, serverless-friendly, great branching workflow	Yes	planetscale.com
Neon	Serverless Postgres, scales to zero (great for side projects)	Yes	neon.tech
Turso	SQLite at the edge, ultra fast reads	Yes	turso.tech
MongoDB Atlas	Document database, good for flexible schemas	Yes	mongodb.com/atlas
Upstash	Serverless Redis — for caching, rate limiting, queues	Yes	upstash.com
Firebase	Google's NoSQL — easy to start, hard to scale off	Yes	firebase.google.com

Rule: Supabase for most projects — you get Postgres, auth, file storage and realtime in one place. Use Neon if you want pure serverless Postgres with Prisma. Use Upstash alongside either for caching.

Authentication

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Clerk ✅ first choice	Fastest to set up, beautiful prebuilt UI, great DX	Yes (10k MAU)	clerk.com
NextAuth / Auth.js	Free, open source, full control, pairs with Prisma	Free	next-auth.js.org
Supabase Auth	Already included if you use Supabase	Yes	supabase.com
Lucia Auth	Lightweight, full control, no magic	Free	lucia-auth.com
Auth0	Enterprise auth, social logins, MFA	Yes (7.5k MAU)	auth0.com

Rule: Clerk if you want it working in 30 minutes. NextAuth/Auth.js if you want full control and free forever. Supabase Auth if your database is already Supabase.

File & Image Storage

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Supabase Storage ✅ if using Supabase	Already included, simple API	Yes	supabase.com
Uploadthing	File uploads designed specifically for Next.js	Yes	uploadthing.com
Cloudinary	Images + video with transforms (resize, crop, optimise on the fly)	Yes	cloudinary.com
AWS S3	Cheap at scale, industry standard	Pay per use	aws.amazon.com
Vercel Blob	Dead simple file storage, works inside Vercel	Yes	vercel.com/storage/blob
Imagekit	Image + video CDN with transforms	Yes	imagekit.io

Rule: Uploadthing for Next.js file uploads — zero config. Cloudinary if you need image transforms (resize, crop, format). Supabase Storage if you're already on Supabase.

Email

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Resend ✅ first choice	Built for developers, React Email templates, simple API	Yes (3k/month)	resend.com
React Email	Write email templates in React + Tailwind	Free	react.email
Nodemailer	Self-hosted, free, full control (use with Gmail/SMTP)	Free	nodemailer.com
SendGrid	High volume transactional email	Yes (100/day)	sendgrid.com
Mailgun	Transactional email, good deliverability	Yes (limited)	mailgun.com
Loops	Marketing + transactional email for SaaS	Yes	loops.so
Postmark	Best deliverability, paid only	No	postmarkapp.com

Rule: Resend + React Email for every project. Write your email templates in React just like your UI. Resend handles delivery.

```bash
npm install resend @react-email/components
```

Payments

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Stripe ✅ only choice	The standard — subscriptions, one-time, invoicing	No (% per transaction)	stripe.com
Lemon Squeezy	Simpler Stripe alternative, handles tax automatically	No	lemonsqueezy.com
Paddle	B2B SaaS, handles global tax and compliance	No	paddle.com

Rule: Stripe for everything. Lemon Squeezy if you want to avoid dealing with global tax (they handle it for you).

CMS (Content Management)

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Sanity ✅ first choice	Flexible, great Next.js integration, real-time editing	Yes	sanity.io
Contentful	Enterprise CMS, large team content workflows	Yes (limited)	contentful.com
Notion as CMS	Use Notion pages as your CMS via API	Free (Notion plan)	developers.notion.com
Payload CMS	Self-hosted, code-first, built with Next.js	Free	payloadcms.com
Keystatic	Git-based CMS, content stored in your repo	Free	keystatic.com
MDX + local files	Blog posts as `.mdx` files in your repo — no CMS needed	Free	—

Rule: MDX files for a personal blog. Sanity when clients need to edit content. Payload when you want a CMS you fully own and control.

Search

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Algolia	Instant search, great DX, fast	Yes (10k records)	algolia.com
Meilisearch	Open source Algolia alternative, self-hostable	Free (self-host)	meilisearch.com
Typesense	Open source, fast, cheaper than Algolia at scale	Free (self-host)	typesense.org
Postgres Full Text Search	Built into Postgres/Supabase — good enough for most apps	Free	—

Rule: Postgres full-text search for most projects — it's already there if you use Supabase. Algolia when search is a core feature and you need instant results with typo tolerance.

Realtime & WebSockets

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Supabase Realtime ✅ if using Supabase	Already included — live table updates, presence	Yes	supabase.com
Pusher	Managed WebSockets, easy to set up	Yes (200k messages)	pusher.com
Ably	Realtime messaging at scale	Yes	ably.com
Liveblocks	Collaborative features — cursors, presence, comments	Yes	liveblocks.io
Partykit	Edge-native realtime, fun DX	Yes	partykit.io

Rule: Supabase Realtime if you're already on Supabase. Pusher for a quick chat or notification feature. Liveblocks if you're building collaborative editing.

Background Jobs & Queues

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Inngest ✅ first choice	Serverless background jobs, scheduled tasks, retries — Next.js native	Yes	inngest.com
Trigger.dev	Background jobs with great DX, open source	Yes	trigger.dev
Upstash QStash	HTTP-based message queue, serverless-friendly	Yes	upstash.com/qstash
BullMQ	Redis-based queues (self-hosted)	Free	github.com/taskforcesh/bullmq

Rule: Inngest for most projects — handles retries, scheduling, and fan-out without a persistent server. Use it for sending emails, processing uploads, scheduled tasks.

Analytics

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Vercel Analytics	Built in if you deploy on Vercel — zero config	Yes	vercel.com/analytics
Plausible	Privacy-friendly, simple, no cookie banner needed	No (paid)	plausible.io
Posthog ✅ first choice	Analytics + feature flags + session replay + A/B testing	Yes	posthog.com
Google Analytics	Free, powerful, but requires cookie consent	Yes	analytics.google.com
Mixpanel	Product analytics, user behaviour tracking	Yes	mixpanel.com
Umami	Open source, self-hostable, privacy-friendly	Free (self-host)	umami.is

Rule: Posthog for most projects — you get analytics, feature flags, and session replay all in one. It's what most indie SaaS builders use.

Error Monitoring

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Sentry ✅ first choice	Industry standard — catches errors with full stack trace	Yes	sentry.io
LogRocket	Error tracking + session replay	Yes	logrocket.com
Highlight.io	Open source Sentry alternative	Yes	highlight.io

Rule: Sentry. Set it up on every project before you ship. You will not regret it.

```bash
npm install @sentry/nextjs
npx @sentry/wizard@latest -i nextjs
```

Feature Flags

Platform	Best for	Free tier	URL
Posthog ✅ first choice	Already there if you use Posthog for analytics	Yes	posthog.com
Vercel Feature Flags	Built into Vercel Edge Config	Yes	vercel.com
LaunchDarkly	Enterprise feature flags	No	launchdarkly.com
Growthbook	Open source A/B testing + feature flags	Yes	growthbook.io

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The Platform Stack for Most Projects

Next.js only (frontend + API routes in one)

```
Hosting        → Vercel
Database       → Supabase (Postgres + auth + storage + realtime)
Auth           → Clerk  OR  Supabase Auth
File uploads   → Uploadthing  OR  Supabase Storage
Email          → Resend + React Email
Payments       → Stripe
Background jobs → Inngest
Analytics      → Posthog
Error tracking → Sentry
```

With a separate Node.js backend

```
Frontend       → Vercel (Next.js)
Backend        → Railway (Node.js + Express/Hono)
Database       → Supabase  OR  Neon (Postgres) + Prisma
Auth           → JWT (jsonwebtoken + bcryptjs)  OR  Clerk
File uploads   → Multer → Supabase Storage  OR  Cloudinary
Email          → Resend + React Email
Payments       → Stripe
Realtime       → Socket.io on your Node server
Background jobs → Node-cron  OR  BullMQ + Upstash Redis
Analytics      → Posthog
Error tracking → Sentry (install on both frontend and backend)
```

Total free tier capacity (Next.js only stack):

- Vercel — 100GB bandwidth/month
- Supabase — 500MB database, 1GB storage, 50k MAU auth

- Clerk — 10,000 MAU
- Resend — 3,000 emails/month
- Posthog — 1M events/month
- Sentry — 5k errors/month

You can build and run a real product for $0 until you have meaningful traction.

Pick the stack above and stick with it. The worst thing you can do is spend a week comparing platforms instead of building.